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How I bootstrapped a fintech to 360k users and $6.7k MRR without raising a single dollar

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We were speaking with Raphael Prince Obodugo, engineer, founder, and one of the quietly determined builders reshaping fintech across Africa, when he leaned back and said something that stopped us mid-note: "We never raised. Not a single dollar." So we asked him to tell us everything.



Raphael

Most founders chase funding from day one. You didn't. Was that a choice or circumstance?

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pitch decks. I was thinking about a real problem: West Africans pooling money for rent, subscriptions, travel, school fees, doing it over WhatsApp groups and spreadsheets, with zero structure and a lot of trust. I built the first version to solve that. Revenue followed the solution, not the other way around.

Walk us through what MySub actually was.

A shared-payment infrastructure for everyday life in West Africa. You want to split a Netflix subscription with four friends, pool rent with your flatmates, or contribute toward someone's school fees, MySub handled all of it cleanly and accountably. No awkward "you owe me" conversations. No lost contributions. It worked because the behavior already existed; we just formalized it.

360,000 users is not a small number. How did you get there without a marketing budget?

Community embedding. We went where the conversations were already happening, digital communities, student groups, young professional networks, and made MySub the obvious tool for what they were already doing. Word of mouth did the heavy lifting because the product solved a felt pain. When something genuinely makes your life easier, you tell people. That's the only growth hack that actually works.

$6.7K MRR bootstrapped is respectable. How did you structure the business to stay profitable?

Ruthless prioritization. I wasn't building features to impress investors. Every decision had to either retain users or generate revenue. We ran a hybrid US-Nigeria entity, which meant navigating two regulatory environments simultaneously, compliance wasn't optional, it was existential. I learned early that in fintech, trust is the product. If users don't trust that their money is safe, nothing else matters.

You got into Startup Lisboa — Portugal's flagship incubator. How did that happen?

MySub caught their attention because the model was genuinely novel. Shared-economy fintech for West Africa wasn't a crowded space, we were among the earliest. Startup Lisboa validated that what we were building had international relevance beyond our home market. It also opened doors to a European